

‘LIKE A THOUSAND FIRES’

WIND-DRIVEN BLAZES DESTROY HOMES; AT LEAST 5 DEAD

PALISADES FIRE: Some residents who fled are anxious to see if houses survived

EATON FIRE: 32,500 told to evacuate as 10,600 acres burn in Altadena, Pasadena



STEVE SALINAS shields himself from the intense heat as he hoses down a neighbor’s rooftop on Sinaloa Avenue during the Eaton fire Wednesday in Altadena.

Embers had key role in L.A.’s fiery catastrophe

By GRACE TOOHEY, ALEX WIGGLESWORTH AND RONG-GONG LIN II

Santa Ana winds are infamous for driving fast-moving fires in Southern California, pushing embers well beyond a blaze’s boundary and into neighborhoods and across major roadways.

But officials say the winds that fueled devastating fires in three parts of Los Angeles County were much more erratic and unpredictable than a typical dry offshore wind pattern — and struck areas unaccustomed to such events.

The life-threatening windstorm that prompted several days of dire warnings exploded into a crisis even worse than expected, with embers flying an estimated two to three miles ahead of established fires and in every direction.

The extraordinary winds have created extreme fire behavior almost impossible to anticipate, confounding efforts to establish secure containment lines or utilize firefighting aircraft. They have also led to major structure losses, widespread evacuations and ongoing destruction.

“Normally, under a sustained Santa Ana condition, we have fires that are long and narrow,” said Anthony [See [Embers](#), A1]



BEACHFRONT HOMES in Malibu are left in ruins on Wednesday. Fire officials acknowledged that they don’t have enough staffing for the enormity of the blazes.

In Altadena, residents step into breach

By JAMES RAINEY, NATHAN SOLIS, MATTHEW ORMSETH, BRITTNY MEJIA AND MELISSA GOMEZ

As the winds whipped out of the north, and embers began to rain down, almost everyone had left J.C. Matsuura’s neighborhood in Altadena.

But Matsuura had no intention of following the evacuation order issued as the

Eaton fire rapidly spread Tuesday night, engulfing homes and businesses that stood in its path. Even after Matsuura’s wife left, taking the family dogs, the 65-year-old stood his ground.

Armed only with a garden hose and determination, Matsuura kept the embers and flames away from his home of 20 years. It was not until a ghastly dawn that a fire crew from the U.S. Forest Service arrived. By then, homes on two sides of Mat-

suura’s had caught fire.

With firefighters stretched thin, with three major fires burning in L.A. County as of Wednesday afternoon, residents such as Matsuura decided to stay and wage a battle to save their homes.

“We’re doing the very best we can. But no, we don’t have enough fire personnel in L.A. County between all the departments to handle this,” L.A. County Fire Chief [See [Altadena](#), A1]

By HANNAH FRY, NOAH HAGGERTY, GRACE TOOHEY, RUBEN VIVES AND RICHARD WINTON

More than 1,100 homes, businesses and other buildings have burned and at least five people are dead in wildfires scorching communities across Los Angeles County, making this one of the most destructive firestorms to hit the region in memory.

All five deaths occurred in and around Altadena and Pasadena, where the Eaton fire exploded Tuesday night, giving residents little time to flee.

In Pacific Palisades, the Palisades fire had charred more than 15,800 acres as of Wednesday afternoon, burning down to Pacific Coast Highway, where it engulfed multimillion-dollar homes along the iconic stretch.

L.A. County Fire Chief Anthony Marrone said during a news conference that while there have been no fatalities in the Palisades fire, officials have seen “a high number of significant injuries to residents who did not evacuate, in addition to first responders.” [See [Wildfires](#), A1]

‘If you go any further you will die’ ON SUNSET, A LUNAR LANDSCAPE

By JACK FLEMMING, SUMMER LIN, HANNAH FRY AND IAN JAMES

A dry wind was already stirring when the sun rose over Pacific Palisades on Tuesday, fitful gusts whipping palm fronds seaward and making eucalyptus limbs creek and groan. The forecast called for an all-out windstorm by midday over chaparral that hadn’t seen rain for eight months.

Fires were predicted all over Southern California. The air was eerie and electric, and residents in “the Palisades” could only pray that nothing ignited, because for all its wealth and beauty, this slice of coastal paradise had all the makings [See [Escape](#), A1]

By Wednesday morning, it looked as if a bomb had detonated on Sunset Boulevard.

As the catastrophic Palisades fire receded from one of the city’s iconic thoroughfares, smoke and ash rendered the once-picturesque landscape into something oddly lunar.

There were charred buildings, some slightly damaged, others fully destroyed. A burned-out Shell station, the pumps intact but the convenience store [See [Palisades](#), A1]

LOS ANGELES FIRES

Palisades hydrants ran dry
A top DWP official cites “tremendous demand on our system” from the wild-fire amid criticism. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Schools heavily damaged
Some Pacific Palisades campuses are devastated, and many others in L.A. could be closed for days. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Smoke chokes L.A. County
Powerful winds are propelling hazardous air as far south as San Pedro and hindering breathing. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Insurance explained
What you should do and can expect from your insurer if you have lost your home to a fire. **BUSINESS, A9**

MORE INSIDE

Mourners reflect on Carter, future
People gather in the cold and the Capitol Rotunda to honor the 39th president, with some observers discussing a jarring transition of political eras. **NATION, A4**

SAG Awards snubs, surprises
The Screen Actors Guild announces its nominees in movies and TV. “Wicked” is the most popular film while “Shogun” leads on TV side. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Santa Ana winds and hazy sunshine. L.A. Basin: 74/48. **B6**

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